

What's Next for Open Collaboration?

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Open collaboration is facing pressures from technology, regulation, and sustainability. Here are my reflections on what's next and what CEOs and CTOs can do today to lead responsibly.

Introduction

For decades, open collaboration (through open source, open data, and open standards) has reshaped industries, democratized access to technology, and accelerated innovation. It is one of the most remarkable social and economic experiments of our time: thousands of individuals and organizations building shared infrastructure across national and corporate boundaries. But the world around us is changing. Geopolitical tensions, the rise of AI, increasing regulatory scrutiny, and questions about sustainability are testing the limits of our current model of openness. If open collaboration is to remain a force for good, it must evolve to continue unlocking innovation and fostering trust.

I've spent the past two decades working with open ecosystems and corporate strategy as an executive director of an open source foundation, an open source executive, and an advisor to companies navigating these questions. I believe that the next five years will determine whether openness remains resilient, relevant, and impactful or risks being diluted and sidelined.

To understand where we need to go, it's essential first to examine where we are today and identify the strengths and weaknesses emerging in our current approach to openness.

Where Are We Today?

Let's start with where we are today. Open collaboration today is both stronger and more fragile than ever. On one hand, it is undeniable that open source powers the digital economy. Nearly every organization, from startups to governments, relies on open source software, open standards, and increasingly, open data. On the other hand, cracks are showing:

- **Community strain:** Many maintainers and core contributors face increasing demands on their time and attention, often with limited support.
- **Corporate dominance:** Large corporations increasingly drive decisions in key ecosystems.
- **Legal and regulatory pressure:** Governments are introducing new regulations (like the EU Cyber Resilience Act or AI Act) that impose new responsibilities on open source actors.
- **AI disruption:** Generative AI raises questions about licensing, attribution, and trust, while also challenging the collaborative culture that made open source thrive.

I've observed how these dynamics create both friction and opportunity, pointing to clear directions for how open collaboration must evolve to remain impactful and relevant. With that perspective in mind, let's explore what the next five years of open collaboration could and should look like.

The Next 5 Years of Open Collaboration

Drawing on my experience working with organizations, communities, and foundations worldwide, I share my reflections on how open collaboration is likely to evolve over the next five years and what that means for those of us who care about its future. Here are some of the key shifts I anticipate will define this next chapter, along with their implications for organizations and leaders today.

- **Openness beyond source code:** Openness is already moving beyond software to include data, AI models, scientific publications, and hardware designs. Over the next five years, I anticipate that more industries will adopt open collaboration models. Organizations that learn to manage openness beyond code will unlock entirely new forms of innovation and collaboration.
- **Open collaboration meets AI:** AI is both a catalyst and a challenge for openness. On one hand, AI tools/frameworks/libraries/platforms lower barriers to entry, helping more people contribute to open source projects and adopt AI tooling. On the other hand, they introduce risks, including a lack of transparency in model training, unclear licensing of outputs, and the potential to automate away meaningful human contributions. We'll need new governance frameworks that integrate AI into open ecosystems without undermining trust.



Figure 1:

- **Resilient and sustainable communities:** Maintainer health and sustainability are increasingly recognized as high-priority issues. Over the years, I've spoken with maintainers who describe the constant balancing act between their enthusiasm for community and the increasing demands placed on them. With better funding, transparent governance, and institutional backing, such pressures can ease and allow maintainers to thrive.
- **From projects to ecosystems:** In my experience, the most impactful open source initiatives emerge not from isolated projects but from well-stewarded ecosystems. Interoperability, shared infrastructure, and standards will matter more than any single repository. The next five years will focus on ecosystem stewardship, with a focus on understanding how projects interconnect and ensuring they thrive collectively.
- **Trust, compliance, and policy:** Regulators are paying closer attention to open source and open data because they power critical infrastructure. Organizations will need to integrate compliance, security, and ethical considerations from the start, not as afterthoughts. Organizations that lead with trust and accountability will stand out (open source is a great example here).

So what can leaders do now to align their organizations with this vision? Here are some concrete steps you can begin taking right away.

Call to Action for Leaders

For CEOs, CTOs, foundation directors, and policymakers, the next five years are a call to stewardship. Here are practical actions you can take now to prepare your organization and ecosystem for what's coming:

1. **Appoint clear ownership of open strategy:** Assign someone (even if it's not their full-time role yet) to oversee your organization's open source and open collaboration strategy. This leader should have visibility into engineering, legal, risk, and community relations, and report regularly to the executive team.
2. **Invest in community health and open governance:** Budget time and money to support the communities and ecosystems you depend on. From over 25 years of working professionally with open source and leading open source programs, one consistent lesson is clear: the health of your dependencies mirrors the health of your product/service. Organizations must support the people who sustain them, fund maintainers, sponsor open source foundations, support open standards, and contribute to governance improvements.
3. **Expand policies to cover emerging domains:** Update your internal policies to address not just software, but also open data, AI models, and open hardware. Develop clear guidelines for what openness means for



Figure 2: Actionable plan for leaders

your business and how to comply with licensing, security, and privacy requirements.

4. **Align contributions with strategy:** Be deliberate about where and how you contribute. Support projects that matter to your business and serve the broader ecosystem. Working within the boundaries of this interaction has the highest impact.
5. **Prepare for regulatory change:** Anticipate compliance obligations stemming from regulations like the EU AI Act, the Cyber Resilience Act, and others. Strengthen your ability to track dependencies, document your supply chain, and respond to audits before you're forced to. Organizations need to begin building those capabilities now rather than scrambling later.
6. **Lead with transparency and inclusivity:** Be clear about your goals, open in your decision-making, and inclusive of diverse voices from your teams and the broader community. Transparency builds trust, internally within your organization and externally within your ecosystem and industry.

Taking these steps will help you navigate the coming challenges and position your organization as a trusted leader in shaping the future of open collaboration. Ultimately, the future of open collaboration rests on the choices leaders make today and the mindset they bring to this shared responsibility.

Conclusion

Over the past two decades, I've seen how it has built the foundations of our digital world, and also seen how fragile it can become when neglected. The next five years will test it through technological disruption, regulatory complexity, and societal expectations. The good news is that we have the tools, the people, the experience, the will, and the vision to make it stronger. What we need now is leadership, leaders who understand that openness is not just a cost to manage or a risk to mitigate, but a strategic asset to invest in.

Collaboration will evolve. The question is whether organizations will help shape that evolution or be left reacting to it. We all have a role to play in this story. Let's make sure we play it well.

About the Author

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